

Chicago Tribune

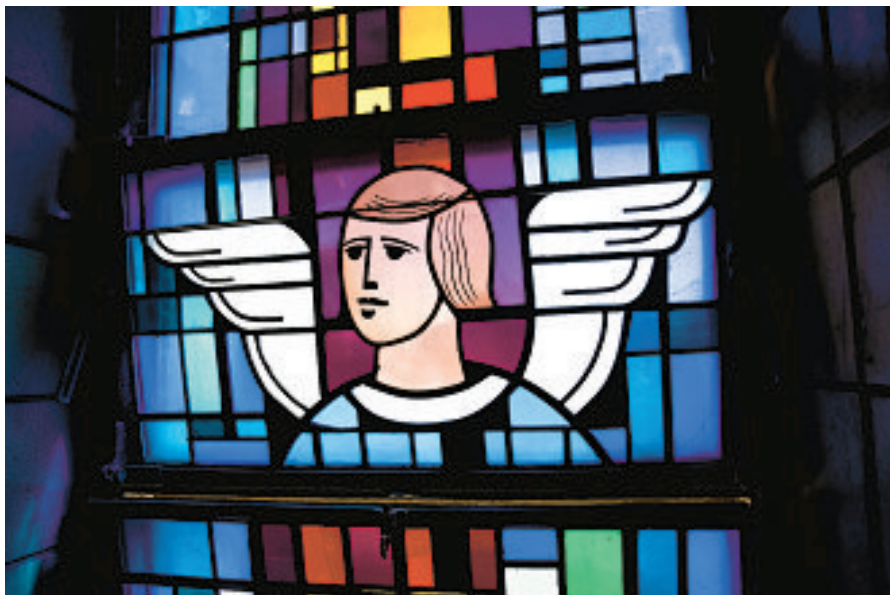
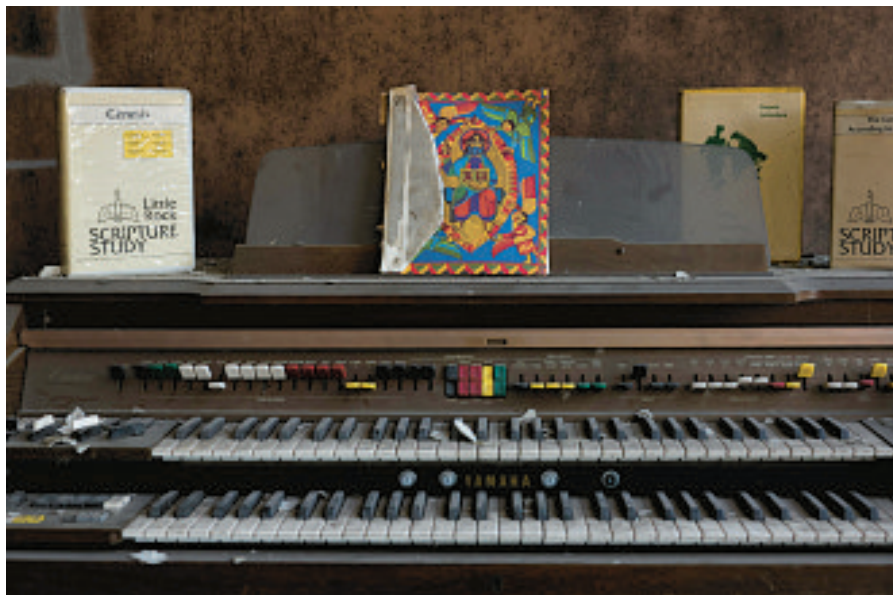


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SATURDAY, MAY 10, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

After a series of closures ordered by the archdiocese, Pope Leo XIV's childhood church in Chicago's Riverdale neighborhood fell into disrepair. Now everything could change for the long-gutted sanctuary



Sudden significance

New pontiff celebrates his initial Mass as details emerge of how votes coalesced in secret conclave

By Nicole Winfield
Associated Press

VATICAN CITY — Pope Leo XIV said Friday that his election is a cross to bear and a blessing as he celebrated his first Mass and details began to emerge on how votes swiftly coalesced to make him history's first U.S.-born pope. Freed from their conclave, cardinals began describing the days and hours leading up to the final ballot Thursday afternoon that brought Leo past the two-thirds majority needed. Many marveled that the Chicago-

born Augustinian missionary Robert Prevost reached the threshold so quickly, given the vast diversity of voters and the traditional taboo against a U.S. pope because of the secular power the country wields. "It is a miracle of the Holy Spirit," said Cardinal Fernando Natalio Chomalí Garib, archbishop of Santiago, Chile. He noted that 133 men who barely knew one another from 70 countries came to an agreement in just over 24 hours. "And also an

Turn to Pope, Page 4

Above: Remnants of the former St. Mary of the Assumption School and Parish church in Chicago's Riverdale neighborhood as they were found this week. New Pope Leo XIV attended the church and school, which were sold in 2019, while growing up nearby in suburban Dolton. **JOHN J. KIM AND E. JASON WAMBSGANS PHOTOS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Caroline Kubzansky | Chicago Tribune

Above the door of the church in the last blocks of Chicago, the Virgin Mary still stands with her arms wide open. The double doors beneath the statue's feet are shut, but a disintegrating wooden side door swings freely, leading to a set of stairs with chipped paint scattered on them. Above, a pool of blue light from a stained-glass window illuminates a balcony where the St. Mary of the Assumption Church choir — including a young boy who would later become the first American-born pope — once sang. Antoinette Nuzzo stepped inside the sanctuary earlier this week, took a look around and thought out loud: "Wow, they took a lot of stuff out of here." Nuzzo, 71, had not been inside St. Mary's since the church's final Mass in the summer of 2011. But she came back Thursday to see what remained of the old sanctuary because it is where Robert Prevost, now Pope Leo XIV, began his formal religious journey.

Turn to Church, Page 4



Robert Droust, left, has his liquor collection evaluated by Unicorn CEO Phil Mikhaylov and auction operations supervisor Daniel Cothorn in Chicago on Wednesday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicago startup is the eBay of imbibing

By Robert Channick | Chicago Tribune

When it comes to liquid assets, a Chicago startup is finding that stocks and bonds may have nothing on bourbon. Unicorn, a five-year-old online auction platform for wines and spirits, has quickly established itself as the eBay of imbibing, authenticating, digitizing, storing and auctioning more than \$125 million worth of prized booze since inception. More than 100,000 custom-

ers have been raiding their liquor cabinets to trade everything from the bargain bin to rare single-barrel bourbons. The weekly auctions have turned more than a few dusty but unopened bottles into five- and six-figure windfalls. "We serve serious collectors and first-time buyers alike," said Phil Mikhaylov, 34, CEO and co-founder of Unicorn.

Turn to Bottles, Page 2

A future weather warning

Federal agency cuts may endanger lives

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Melanie Snow and her husband talk about the weather like it's gossip. Every day, they read National Weather Service discussions — technical documents from the agency where meteorologists explain the reasoning and rationale behind forecasts — from weather events in Chicago and across the country. "We avidly consume those," Snow said. "And we're definitely the people in our circle of friends who, if they really want to know



Weather aficionado Melanie Snow in Chicago's Lincoln Park on Thursday. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

the weather for their vacation, wedding, birthday party outside, etcetera, they call us and say: 'Give me the lowdown.'" The couple met in college at Georgia Tech, where they both studied to become meteorologists. Then they didn't. She became a science educator and he became an actuary, but the weather bug stuck with them. Now, weather hobbyists and

enthusiasts — some like Snow and her husband, who might prefer to watch storm clouds from the safety of their porch and others who'd rather chase severe weather for the thrill — are feeling anxious about what federal funding and staffing cuts under the Trump administration could mean for the data they rely

Turn to Weather, Page 2

Trial nears in boy's death

A trial is set to begin soon in an 11-year-old's killing — a case that drew scrutiny over protections for domestic violence victims. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Called up for the Cubs

Top pitching prospect Cade Horton is ready to make his major league debut for a team with a rotation gutted by injuries. **Chicago Sports**

